

1,667 square miles (4,317 square km) in a large depression in the Qilian Mountains and lies at 10,515 ft (3,205 m) above sea level. Most of the rivers that once discharged into Qinghai Hu now run dry before they reach it, mostly because water is diverted from them for irrigation. Consequently, the lake is shrinking.

Jiuzhaigou Valley National Park

Location The Minshan Mountains of Sichuan, central China

This extraordinarily beautiful valley has been afforded World Heritage Site status for its superb landscape features. Notably, these include numerous blue, green, and turquoise lakes with clear, mineral-rich water, spectacular waterfalls, and limestone terraces set below high

peaks. The valley also boasts classic limestone features such as caves and a variety of old-growth forest habitats, which are home to a population of giant pandas.

Xiaozhai Tiankeng

Location Chongqing municipality, central China

Xiaozhai Tiankeng is the world's largest and deepest sinkhole. On the surface, it has a diameter of

more than 1,640 ft (500 m), and apart from one sloping ledge, its walls descend vertically 2,172 ft (662 m) through the bedrock to Di Feng Cave, into which the limestone of the sinkhole dissolved and was washed away by the subterranean Migong River. Although local people have long known about Xiaozhai, naming it the Heavenly Pit, it was only discovered by western explorers in 1994.

▼ FALL LANDSCAPE AT JIUZHAIGOU VALLEY NATIONAL PARK

